

Sentence correction

COMPLETE LEARNING GUIDE

What You'll Learn

Sentence correction questions test grammatical accuracy directly — subject-verb agreement, tense consistency, parallel structure, pronoun clarity, modifier placement, correct prepositions/idioms, and concise phrasing — by presenting a flawed sentence and asking for the grammatically correct version. The key skill is spotting the SPECIFIC error category quickly rather than vaguely sensing 'something sounds off,' since most placement tests structure wrong options around one clear, nameable grammar rule rather than stylistic preference. This sub-module works through the seven error categories that account for the overwhelming majority of sentence-correction questions, with a broken sentence and its fix shown side by side for each, so the pattern-recognition (not just the rule) becomes fast and automatic under time pressure.

1. Subject-Verb Agreement

The verb must agree in number with the TRUE grammatical subject, not with a noun that happens to sit closer to the verb (often inside a prepositional phrase) — this is the single most tested sentence-correction error.

- Incorrect: 'The list of items are on the table.' (verb wrongly agrees with 'items' instead of the true subject 'list'.) Correct: 'The list of items is on the table.'

2. Tense Consistency

Within a single sentence describing related events, the tenses must logically align — mixing past continuous with present tense for events that should be in the same timeframe is a common, easily-spotted error.

- Incorrect: 'She was studying for two hours when the phone rings.' Correct: 'She was studying for two hours when the phone rang.' (both verbs describe the past).

3. Parallelism

Items in a list or comparison must share the same grammatical form (all gerunds, all infinitives, all nouns) — mixing forms within one list is a very common and easily fixed error.

- Incorrect: 'He likes swimming, to run, and cycling.' Correct: 'He likes swimming, running, and cycling.' (all three items now share the -ing gerund form).

4. Pronoun Reference and Ambiguity

A pronoun (he, him, his, it, they) must clearly refer to exactly one possible noun — if a sentence has two candidates the pronoun could plausibly refer to, it's ambiguous and needs rewriting, often by replacing the pronoun with the actual name.

- Incorrect (ambiguous): 'When Raj met Arjun, he gave him his book.' (unclear who 'he', 'him', and 'his' refer to). Correct: 'Raj gave Arjun his own book.' or restructure with explicit names.

5. Modifiers: Dangling and Misplaced

A modifying phrase at the start of a sentence must logically describe the very next noun that follows it — if it doesn't (a 'dangling modifier'), the sentence technically describes something nonsensical.

- Incorrect: 'Walking through the park, the flowers looked beautiful.' (this literally says the flowers were walking). Correct: 'Walking through the park, I thought the flowers looked beautiful.'

6. Idioms and Prepositions

Certain words pair with fixed, non-negotiable prepositions by idiomatic convention rather than logical rule — these have to be memorized as fixed phrases rather than derived from general grammar rules.

- Incorrect: 'He is good in mathematics.' Correct: 'He is good at mathematics.' (the fixed idiom is 'good at', not 'good in').

7. Redundancy and Conciseness

Phrases that repeat the same meaning twice ('reason...because', 'return back', 'free gift') should be trimmed to their single clearest form — correctness questions frequently include an option that fixes the grammar but leaves redundant phrasing, which is still the wrong choice if a cleaner option exists.

- Incorrect (redundant): 'The reason why he failed is because he didn't study.' Correct: 'He failed because he didn't study.' (removes the redundant 'the reason why...is because' construction entirely).

Common Pitfalls

- Matching the verb to the nearest noun (often inside a prepositional phrase) instead of the true grammatical subject.
- Mixing tenses within a sentence describing events that should share the same timeframe.
- Listing items in different grammatical forms (gerund, infinitive, noun) within the same list or comparison instead of keeping them parallel.

- Leaving a pronoun ambiguous when two nouns in the sentence could both plausibly be its referent.
- Placing a modifying phrase where it grammatically describes the wrong noun (dangling/ misplaced modifiers).
- Guessing prepositions by logic instead of recalling the fixed idiomatic pairing ('good at', not 'good in').
- Choosing an option that's grammatically correct but still redundant when a more concise correct option is available.

Key Takeaways

- Find the TRUE subject before checking verb agreement — ignore nouns inside prepositional phrases between subject and verb.
- Keep all items in a list or comparison in the same grammatical form (parallelism).
- A pronoun must have exactly one clear possible referent — rewrite with a name if there's any ambiguity.
- A modifying phrase at a sentence's start must describe the very next noun that follows it.
- Prepositions in idioms are fixed by convention ('good at', 'interested in') and must be memorized, not derived logically.
- Between two grammatically correct options, prefer the more concise one that removes redundancy.

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Purdue OWL — Grammar Resources

https://owl.purdue.edu/owl/general_writing/grammar/index.html

IndiaBix — Verbal Ability: Spotting Errors

<https://www.indiabix.com/verbal-ability/spotting-errors/>